

Five Traditions in Black Political Thought

Tradition	Core Argument
Black Liberalism	Black freedom is achievable within American democratic institutions — through civil rights, legal reform, and full inclusion in political and economic life. Liberals appeal to America's founding ideals and press the country to live up to them. They believe interracial coalition is possible and treat racism as a correctable flaw rather than a structural necessity.
Black Nationalism	Race is the fundamental category for understanding Black life in America, and American society is irredeemably racist. Black people constitute a nation — or should — and freedom requires collective self-determination, autonomous institutions, and separation from white America (cultural, political, economic, or in some versions territorial).
Black Marxism	Racial oppression cannot be separated from capitalism — they are structurally intertwined. Black liberation requires not just civil rights but the transformation of the economic order. White workers are unreliable allies; solidarity with anticolonial struggles internationally matters more.
Black Feminism	Black women's experience — at the intersection of race, gender, and class — requires its own political analysis. It cannot be subsumed under white feminism (which ignores race) or male-dominated Black politics (which ignores gender and sexuality). These oppressions are simultaneous, not additive, and any politics that treats one axis as primary will fail Black women and ultimately everyone. Black feminism is especially critical of ideologies that assign Black women a subordinate role in the struggle.
Black Conservatism	Black progress depends primarily on self-help, moral character, and economic development — not state intervention, protest politics, or claims of special treatment based on historical suffering. Markets are more reliable vehicles for Black advancement than politics. Policies that appear to benefit Black communities but undermine self-reliance or individual dignity are both immoral and counterproductive.

Adapted from

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